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California's $12 billion science bond hangs by a thread after ballot deadline

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Lawmakers are scrambling to reach a deal with the governor and other state leaders to get a $12 billion science bond on the November ballot that would backfill research grants at the University of California that have been threatened by the Trump administration.

The deadline to get the bond on the ballot passed Thursday, but the bill's supporters say there is still a "narrow path forward" to put the measure before voters — if Gov. Gavin Newsom, the Assembly speaker and the Senate president pro tempore are willing to negotiate.

"The Trump Administration's destruction of federal science agencies and cuts to science research directly threaten core pillars of California's economy and treatments that represent hope to millions of families," said Sen. Scott Wiener, two of the bill's other authors and a union leader in a joint statement urging collaboration. "This moment calls for real urgency."

The last-ditch efforts to negotiate over the bond come amid some of the most chaotic ballot deadline negotiations in recent history. On the Thursday deadline, lawmakers passed last-minute deals to place two additional measures on the ballot and swap one previously passed measure for another. Lawmakers and ballot measure proponents also announced deals to pull several previously qualified measures — including two competing measures over Uber's liability and another capping healthcare executive pay — from the ballot.

All the last-minute dealmaking occurred as Newsom and lawmakers hammered out the state budget. They were facing a Saturday deadline to get all budget bills finalized in time for a vote in the next week, though Assembly Budget Committee Chair Jesse Gabriel told reporters Wednesday he hoped they would wrap up those negotiations by Friday.

Wiener made the science bond one of his priorities this session as a way to combat Trump policies that have jeopardized what has historically been a reliable stream of research dollars across the University of California system.

The bill needs to be approved by the Legislature and signed by Newsom before it can appear on November's ballot, where it needs the majority of voters' support to pass. Wiener, D-San Francisco, first introduced the general obligation bond at $23 billion, but lawmakers slashed the fund by nearly half during negotiations in the Senate, where it passed 29-9 last month.

Chair of the Assembly Appropriations Committee Buffy Wicks compared the ongoing bond negotiations to similar conversations happening over the state's budget during a Wednesday hearing. Newsom, the Assembly speaker and the Senate president pro tempore need to reach an agreement before the bill can move ahead.

"If a three-party agreement is reached, it can move out of suspense," Wicks said.

The suspense file is a holding place for expensive bills — and that's where the bond is parked now and could die. The bill, SB895, has bipartisan support including nearly 30 assembly members as co-authors, said Assembly Member José Luis Solache Jr., D-Lynwood (Los Angeles County).

Mike Miller, who represents more than 60,000 academic and professional staff members within the UC system through the United Automobile Workers union, said failed negotiations would be disastrous for researchers desperate for stability.

"It is going to mean more cuts to scientific research from the Trump administration and the politicization of science research by the Trump administration — and a major hit to the California economy," Miller said.

President Donald Trump last year froze more than $600 million to fund UC research that a judge eventually restored months later. Trump leadership at the National Institutes of Health also scaled back the number of new research grants it funded in 2025 to 3,900 from 5,000 the year before under President Joe Biden. Grants for Alzheimer's disease research were cut in half and new cancer research grants dropped by 23%, according to federal data.

This year, the NIH's spending has fallen about $1 billion behind its usual pace, delaying research and keeping labs from hiring scientists across UC labs and the country.

"The current administration in Washington is taking a wrecking ball to scientific research in this country," Wiener said Wednesday. "It is methodically destroying each of the federal science agencies, completely obliterating them. It is doing everything it can to slash science funding to universities, including the University of California."

Wiener pointed to a $2 million UCSF research grant that has already been cut that focused on viruses that cause diseases such as meningitis and polio. He said the research could have led to new vaccines and other therapies. He also mentioned a cut $5 million grant for further research on T-cell receptors, which trigger immune system response, that he said could have led to immunotherapy treatments for autoimmune diseases and cancer.

"This is not theoretical," Wiener said. "It's real, it's happening today, and it's going to have impacts for years and generations if we don't step up and do anything about it."

Regardless of how the science bond's negotiations conclude, voters will have at least one other large bond to decide on this November. That one is a $11.25 billion fund to grow affordable housing stock.

"We urge the Assembly, Senate, and Governor to come to the table to negotiate a deal to give SB 895 a fair vote and put the science bond on the ballot this November," Wiener, Solache, Miller and Assembly Member Darshana Patel, D-San Diego, said in the joint statement. "A bipartisan coalition of Alzheimer's and Parkinson's patients, scientists, workers, unions, environmental organizations, healthcare workers, and more are fighting for California to stand up for science in the face of an unprecedented federal assault. Let's deliver for them."

Sophia Bollag and Kathryn Palmer contributed to this report.

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